

THE RIGHT TO VOTE

1893

After years of campaigning led by the suffragist Kate Sheppard, New Zealand becomes the first country in the world to grant women the right to vote in national elections.

1906

Finland becomes the first European country to grant the vote to women in 1906. It is also the first European nation to allow women to stand as candidates in elections.

1920–1965

In the US, women are granted the right to vote in 1920, but several local measures deny this right to Black voters. The Voting Rights Act of 1965 outlaws this discrimination.

1929

Ecuador becomes the first Latin American country to grant women the right to vote. It adopts a new constitution in 1929 that extends voting rights to literate women above the age of 21.

1956

Egyptian women are given the vote in 1956. Doria Shafik, a women's rights activist, leads the campaign through demonstrations and an eight-day hunger strike.



DORIA SHAFIK

BRITISH SUFFRAGE ►

In the UK, there were two groups of suffrage campaigners. The Suffragists believed in peaceful methods while the Suffragettes were willing to take direct action. The Suffragettes were led by Emmeline Pankhurst (right). They smashed windows and cut telegraph lines, and were often jailed for their actions. In prison, they went on hunger strikes to protest.

Women's rights

Throughout history, women have been denied rights that men take for granted. In the past two centuries, women around the world have fought for greater equality, whether that means voting in an election, receiving an education, owning property, or getting paid as much as men to do the same job. But the battle is far from over.

Historically, most men who lived in democracies had the right to elect their chosen representatives. Women were not given this right automatically, but had to fight for it. From the late 19th century, women in Western countries began to campaign for suffrage (the right to vote) and today there are very few countries that don't allow women to vote.

Women then focused on other inequalities. In the 1960s, a new movement began in the US, with demands that ranged from equality in pay to more access to birth-control

methods. As more women activists from other countries came together to discuss their issues in forums such as the United Nations, the movement spread. Over the years, subsequent campaigns have helped create laws that are more just toward women.

While the movements that began in the West focused on white women, today, there is a growing awareness that women from different cultures and backgrounds may face a variety of challenges, for example, because of their racial identity. It has led to many new movements across the world.

